

RHETORICAL ANALYSIS MATRIX

American Literature | Jonathan Edwards - 'Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God' (1741)

Ethos, Pathos, & Logos Analysis

Rhetorical Appeal	Primary Objective	Direct Textual Evidence	Analytical Breakdown & Impact
Ethos <i>(Credibility & Authority)</i>	Establishes the speaker as an uncompromised messenger of divine truth and scriptural authority.	"It is nothing but the mere pleasure of God, and that of an angry God, without any promise or obligation at all, that keeps you from destruction."	Edwards shifts personal agency entirely to God. By adopting a calm, detached, and authoritative delivery, he frames himself not as an author of malice, but as an objective reporter delivering unalterable spiritual facts.
Pathos <i>(Emotional Dread & Urgency)</i>	Induces visceral fear, physical instability, and intense psychological panic to shatter complacency.	"The God that holds you over the pit of hell, much as one holds a spider, or some loathsome insect over the fire, abhors you..."	Objectifies the listener as a helpless, repulsively fragile creature hanging by a thread. The sensory diction of fire, weight, and sudden collapse forces an urgent emotional drive toward repentance.
Logos <i>(Internal Theological Logic)</i>	Constructs a cause-and-effect argument based on Calvinist predestination and divine sovereignty.	"There is no reason to be given, why you have not dropped into hell this very moment, but only that God's hand has held you up."	Uses deductive reasoning: If God is infinitely powerful and human virtue cannot earn salvation, then survival at any given second is logically dependent solely on divine restraint.

Guided Student Discussion Prompts

1. Diction & Imagery: How does Edwards's choice of the word *"loathsome"* in the spider metaphor alter the listener's self-perception within Puritan theology?

2. Rhetorical Pivot: Near the conclusion, Edwards shifts from terror to hope (*"And now you have an extraordinary opportunity..."*). How does the preceding dread make this final appeal to Pathos more persuasive?

3. Delivery vs. Diction: Historical accounts note that Edwards read his sermon in a calm, monotone voice. Why might a restrained delivery amplify the terror of such violent textual imagery?